

Chapter Eight

TOWARD A PHILOSOPHY OF THE SOCIAL – PART TWO: WHITEHEAD ON SOCIOLOGY, SOCIETIES AND THE SOCIAL

In the first chapter of this book, I discussed how one of my aims was to outline what I have termed a “philosophy of the social”. I set out my initial view of such an enterprise as comprising not *the* philosophy of the social but as remaining with a set of problems which arose within the theoretical approaches of Durkheim, Marx and Weber. The following chapters then traced the character and status of the problem of the social in the works of these writers and provided a more detailed reading of why the social has, and still does, constitute a problem for sociology and social theory.

In this final chapter, I want to provide an approach to the social which recognizes the importance and difficulties of accounting for sociality within contemporary theory, and builds on some of the suggestions and ideas that were encountered in the texts of Durkheim, Marx and Weber. The mainstay of my argument will be the work of A. N. Whitehead. This choice might seem surprising, for even though Whitehead was a philosopher who was interested in the operations of sociology (see, for example, Whitehead 1933, 3–127), it might not immediately seem apparent why his work is relevant to this task. I have previously made moves which have tried to justify this choice (Halewood 2005, 2008, 2009, 2011) and instead of revisiting these arguments, I will first present an analysis of Whitehead’s distinctive understanding of sociology which is offered as an innovative alternative to current approaches.

Before proceeding, it should be stated that while the material offered in this chapter is envisaged as a contribution to a philosophy of the social, it is not intended to provide a comprehensive theory of the social which solves or explains, once and for all, all the facets of the problem of the social which have been raised throughout this book. I believe such a theory to be impossible. Indeed the desire for such an overarching explanation goes against my understanding of the role and status of a philosophy of the social which,

as Karsenti (2013) points out, must always be situated with regard to specific problems, ones that arise from within sociology and social theory, rather than being abstractly imposed upon them. Hopefully, and thankfully, the days when we expected all our conceptual problems to be solved by some general theory are over. In this sense, my aim is more modest but, for that reason, more pertinent. The three “local” problems that I have chosen to address, through the work of Whitehead, are: the status of sociology in relation to ideas and humans; the concept of social order; and the status of societies and their relation to nature. It is important to stress that these latter discussions are not intended as a description of the development of empirical, actual, individual societies. Whitehead is not offering a simple description of reality. This is not the aim or point of such a philosophy.

As will be seen throughout this chapter, what Whitehead offers is a way of thinking about sociology, societies, sociality and the social which is able to avoid some of the problems that were identified in the works of Durkheim, Marx and Weber, which means that we can retain the power and usefulness of a concept of the social, rather than having to dismiss it. A philosophy of the social does not tell us what to think but it might help us to think more productively. I will start by looking at Whitehead’s very specific understanding of the term “sociology”.

Whitehead’s “Sociology”

As I have discussed elsewhere (Halewood 2009; 2011, 84–86), Whitehead was very careful with his use of words in regard to the distinction between the dual terms of society and the social, as opposed to sociology and the sociological. These two sets of terms do not necessarily match or deal with the same concerns. Although primarily a philosopher, Whitehead was much more careful and precise when discussing the social than were Durkheim, Marx and even Weber. This precision is one reason why Whitehead’s work is so pertinent in developing a philosophy of the social and can be helpful in clarifying and avoiding certain enduring problems. For Whitehead, the terms “society” and “social” refer to the metaphysical aspect of his argument; they demarcate the manner in which the things of the world come to endure. Such societies and their enactment of sociality are widespread and are not premised on, or limited to, the activity of humans. As was seen in previous chapters, one abiding problem for many social theorists is that they start off by assuming that societies are predominantly human entities. Whitehead avoids this difficulty by starting at the metaphysical level, but it later becomes clear that what applies to wider modes of existence will also apply to what are normally considered to be human societies. When Whitehead does discuss

societies which are primarily human, he deploys the words “sociology” and “sociological” to do so. However, a word of warning should be raised here. When Whitehead does talk about human societies, his understanding of this term is quite different from any such conception as usually understood. This is an advantage in that Whitehead is free from some of the shackles of traditional sociological thinking and is able to develop a theoretical account which is coherent and comprehensive and provides a firmer framework for contemporary considerations of the social.

Whitehead’s most sustained consideration of the status of human societies (as opposed to his metaphysical account, as given in *Process and Reality*) is to be found in Part I of *Adventures of Ideas* (Whitehead 1933, 3–127) which is aptly titled “Sociological”. This can, at first sight, appear to be a slightly traditional, old-fashioned, even limited account of the development of Western “civilization”, given that it seems to trace the history of mentalities from Greek philosophy to early twentieth-century UK and USA, via the rise of the early Christian Church, the Reformation, and positivism, amongst other factors. It is not my aim here to defend the content of Whitehead’s account, although it is interesting to note that there are resonances with Simmel’s notion of the need for a “General Sociology” which demarcates the wide, historical, shifts in human thought and existence (see Simmel 1950, 16–21).

In these pages, Whitehead does not define the term “sociology” but he does use it in a variety of ways and I believe that it is possible to eke out a clear understanding of what he means by identifying the shared concerns which run through these diverse usages. To jump ahead, sociology has something to do with understanding *how* humans are, and have been, made human. This search for the “how” is in sharp contrast to any search for “what” makes humans human. A search for a “what” is liable to fall into essentialism. The search for a “how” will provide a fuller grasp of what we have become and what we might yet be. This emphasis on process is something that Whitehead shares with Marx and Simmel. The focus on “how” returns us to the importance of the adverbial which has been touched on throughout the previous chapters.

So, although Whitehead uses the adjective “sociological” roughly twenty times in Part I of *Adventures of Ideas*, to my knowledge, he only resorts to the specific word “sociology” three times. On the first occasion, he states: “The religion of Plato is founded on his conception of what a God can be [...] and his sociology is derived from his conception of what a man can be” (Whitehead 1933, 13). Here “sociology” is not “the study of” something; it is more of a theoretical description of what *could be* rather than what *is*. There is some resonance with Whitehead’s description of his own philosophical approach as “speculative” as set out in Chapter I of *Process and Reality* (Whitehead 1978, 3–17). Here, the emphasis is not on listing the facts of existence (or, by analogy,

of the social world) but of carving out a forward-looking conceptual scheme which is coherent, adequate and applicable to that which exists, has existed, and will come to exist (Whitehead 1978, 3). Sociology, therefore, clearly has something to do with humans but it is not simply an analysis of what humans are, in terms of their relations with each other. It is both more and less than that. It is the attempt to draw out what it is that makes us what we are, and points to what we could be. There are, therefore, some links with the approach of Marx, in that nothing is taken for granted. What is required is a framework which can account for the processes which inform the current world and point to the inevitability of change for that world. There is, however, no sense of determinism or the positing of an ideal future to which we should all aim.

In his second reference to sociology in *Adventures of Ideas*, Whitehead states:

There were great civilizations. But they became arrested, and the arrest is the point of our enquiry. We have to understand the reasons for the greatness and the final barriers to advancement. Of course, such an ambitious design is absurd. It would mean the solution of the main problem of sociology. What can be done, is to note some indications of relevant tones of mind apparently widely spread in various districts at different epochs. (Whitehead 1933, 100)

On this occasion, there does seem to be a nod toward sociology as the study of something. Yet, that which it studies is not human societies as such. Rather, it is the processes which enable the rise of “civilizations” which is of interest, as well as the forces which inhibit such processes.¹ Whitehead also indicates that it is impossible to provide a once and for all account or reason for such developments. Sociology can never be complete. What can be offered, however, is an analysis of the “relevant tones of mind” which manifest themselves throughout history. It is not that there are simply states of minds or sets of ideas which are to be discovered. Rather, there are the manners, the modes, in which minds operate. It is a question of how minds think, not just what they think; though it should be noted that Whitehead has not made it clear what constitutes such minds, as yet. This mention of “how” might remind us of the procedures of ethnomethodology which correctly identified the importance of focussing on how people make sense of the world. But Whitehead means more than identifying localized problems. As with Durkheim and Marx, the claim is that it is the manner of association which makes a society what it is. It is always a question of “how” as well as an account of “what”.

Such assertions are linked to Whitehead’s third reference to sociology in *Adventures of Ideas*. Building on the declaration that it is “tones of mind” which are of interest, Whitehead states that he wants to identify how those factors “which were present sporadically and as the dreams of individuals, or as a

faint tinge upon other modes of mentality, received a new importance [...] The question is to understand how this shift of emphasis happened, and to recognize the effects of this shift upon the sociology of the Western World” (Whitehead 1933, 10). Here “sociology” seems to refer to a way of being; the way of being of a certain epoch or “civilization”. The task that Whitehead sets himself is to analyse this in terms of the changing “modes of mentality” which suffuse different epochs.

As will have been noticed, there is a different shade of meaning in each of Whitehead’s three deployments of “sociology”; yet running through all of them is an interest not so much in what makes humans human but *how* humans have been made human, and the role of mentality within this. Such concerns and interest might appear, to many, to be a form of philosophical or sociological idealism – what makes us human are our ideas, what makes us social humans are our shared ideas and ideas of each other. Such a charge might seem to be substantiated by Whitehead’s general description of his aim in writing the first section of *Adventures of Ideas*. “The first part of this book is occupied with the most general aspect of the sociological functions arising from, and issuing into, ideas concerning the human race” (Whitehead 1933, 10). Such a reading can only be made if it is assumed that we already know what ideas are – they are that which humans have and, more importantly, they are that which humans generate. But this is not the case for Whitehead. C. W. Mills once famously described the sociological imagination as “a mess of ideas from German philosophy and British economics” (Mills 2000 [1959], 211). There seems to be some justification for such an assertion. Indeed, it is remarkable how far the ideas of Kant and Hegel stretched into classical social theory through the various filters of writers such as Dilthey and Rickert, among others. One reason that Whitehead is so fruitful for reapproaching the concept of the social is that his philosophy is not weighed down by the baggage of Kant and Hegel, where an enduring question is that of the relation of concepts to reality. Indeed, Whitehead describes his philosophy as “a recurrence to pre-Kantian modes of thought” (Whitehead 1978, xi) which means that the philosophical basis which he develops is in sharp contrast to the mix of positivism and Kantianism which is to be found in Durkheim, Marx’s on-going battles with Hegel, and the specific version of German Idealist neo-Kantianism which influenced Weber and Simmel. In some respects, all of these positions involve a specific conception of what constitutes an idea. This is something that Whitehead was also concerned with but his understanding is not influenced by any form of German idealism and it is important not to reduce his account to such a position. There is something very surprising in Whitehead’s notion of an idea, even though this is announced quietly. For, as Isabelle Stengers has pointed out in an interview with Steven Meyer in Buffalo

on 26 September 2011, what Whitehead is asking us to realize is that “Ideas are things”.²

We must pay attention to what it might mean to argue that “ideas are things”. Indeed, this is exactly what Whitehead is trying to do throughout Part I of *Adventures of Ideas*, and this is key to what he understands by sociology and the sociological. A crucial point is that we should not start by thinking of ideas as the creations of humans: “I propose to consider critically the *sort* of history which ideas can have in the life of humanity” (Whitehead 1933, 3. Emphasis in original). This clearly lays out his position: it is ideas which are the focus of his interest, the “life of humanity” is, in a sense, secondary. Ideas are things which have their own existence. It might turn out that this existence is played out through the life of humanity but this does not mean that ideas are the creations of humanity. So, while it is possible, indeed it is ultimately vital, to analyse how ideas intersect with humans and what ideas can do for them, this should not be the starting point. Clearly, Whitehead is not setting out some simple “history of ideas”, for two reasons. First, Whitehead does not consider ideas to be either the products of a specific social or cultural epoch or, alternatively, simply the creations of “great minds”. Second, as Whitehead makes clear, his version of history differs from any usual sense of this word, as his phrase “the *sort* of history” makes clear. He is attempting to map out a new approach to history which does not posit ideas as entities which can be studied on their own terms, but nor are they reducible to the isolated creations of humans. Faithful to his more general philosophical position that there are no self-sufficient entities in existence, as each entity relies upon other entities in order to come into being and to endure, Whitehead envisages ideas and humanity as distinct and yet fundamentally interrelated. Ideas play themselves out in and through humanity. This is why we must take literally the title of his 1933 work *Adventures of Ideas*. Ideas have their own adventures, though these adventures might only be discovered within the history of humanity. Ideas have their own lives but do not exist outside of the life of humanity. Whitehead makes a similar point in *Modes of Thought* (1938) when he is discussing consciousness, as opposed to ideas:

Clear, conscious discrimination is an accident of human existence. It makes us human. But it does not make us exist. It is of the essence of our humanity. But it is an accident of our existence. (Whitehead 1938, 158)

There is an important distinction to be made between human existence and humanity. We could have existed, in some sense, as physically “human” without clear, conscious discrimination. But we would have lacked humanity. Whitehead dips into the lexicon of scholastic philosophy to make his point,

by drawing a distinction between “essence” and “accident”. Conscious discrimination is essential for our humanity but it is not necessary for our simple existence as humans; it is, in this respect, accidental. Its role was not to make us humans. Becoming human, becoming a specific kind of ape, did not require the facility of clear, conscious discrimination, though now that part of our existence seems so important that it is difficult to imagine a version of humans without such discrimination. But this does not make it essential to what we are now; in this respect it is accidental. Conscious discrimination makes us into a specific version of humans, in so far as we have humanity rather than “ape-ity”.

Fragmentary intellectual agencies co-operated blindly to turn apes into men [*sic*], to turn the classic civilization into mediaeval Europe, to overwhelm the Renaissance by the Industrial Revolution. *Men [sic] knew not what they did.* (Whitehead 1933, 9. Emphasis added)

Ideas, considered as things which are separate from humans, operated as intellectual agencies. However, these ideas did not themselves have foresight, they did not decide to invent humans, to mould them out of apes, but they were the primary factor in this process. Conversely, humans did not generate their ideas out of nothing; “men [*sic*] knew not what they did”. Humans were, rather, the vehicles which enabled ideas to come into efficacy. A record of the ways in which humanity and ideas combine is precisely the “*sort of history*” that Whitehead wants to elicit.

In light of this, it is interesting to think what might have happened if Kant had been born a century later and written his *Critique of Pure Reason* having read Darwin’s *On the Origin of Species*. Modern thought, modern philosophy, might have been very different if the bounds of our thinking had been traced on the basis of a recognition that clear, conscious discrimination was an outcome and not a premise. In this respect, human reason should be firmly situated as animal reason. This would not be to relativize such reason or to reduce its successes (and failures) to instinct or the unfolding of pre-programmed DNA. It would not render the findings of science unreal or ineffective, in the way that some have attempted to reduce science to an epiphenomenon of society. Instead, it would be to insist that we pay due attention to the manner in which human reason is situated within “nature” and yet has its own specific place within such nature. Such thoughts, such novel approaches to old, seemingly intractable, problems are precisely the kind of approach that Whitehead and a philosophy of the social could allow for and develop in a more consistent form. I am aware that I have not fully substantiated what it might mean to treat human reason as a version of ape reason, but I do think that such insights are

important and point to possible further avenues of research. It is in this way that a philosophy of the social might proceed. Not by immediately providing answers or solutions to all questions regarding the social but by developing new lines of thought. Such research might find interesting material in the work of Durkheim, especially in his analyses of the “social as natural” and the importance of the development of collective concepts which take on a life of their own.

Overall, Whitehead’s understanding of sociology is not to be seen as setting out a programme for the discipline in the way that Durkheim and Weber attempted to do. Whitehead’s sociology is not a manifesto. He is not so much laying down rules to follow but opening up novel ways of thinking which might help us move beyond some of the problems which plague sociology and social theory. Whitehead’s approach might seem peculiar to some but this is not necessarily a bad thing. If we are to move beyond the somewhat sluggish approach to the social which seems to have infected sociology after Parsons, then it will take some originality to re-energize these arguments. At the same time, it might seem to some that Whitehead does owe us a little more evidence. Therefore, the following sections will trace, in more detail, another example of how Whitehead offers a novel approach to the problem of the social through a discussion of the character and status of “nature” and “societies”.

The Order of Nature and the Creation of Societies

In *Process and Reality*, Whitehead provides his most detailed account of the relation of nature and societies in two sections titled “The Order of Nature” and “Organisms and their Environment” (Whitehead 1978, 83ff.). This might seem to suggest that Whitehead believes that there is an order to nature which is distinct from an active social realm, and this runs the risk of painting him as a somewhat traditional thinker. It would situate Whitehead as an advocate of the abiding split between the hard, natural sciences which are concerned with the blind, mechanistic laws of the physical world, and those softer, sociocultural analyses, which deal with the contingent patterns of human behaviour. Even if it is agreed that the study of the social is indeed scientific, there are few who would nowadays maintain that the laws which supposedly govern the objects and subjects of the social arena can be delineated with the same kind of certainty as that which physicists claim for themselves. There remains, therefore, an apparent gulf between the kind of order to be found in nature and that which might be tentatively traced in the political, economic or cultural realm. Is this Whitehead’s position? The answer is certainly “no”. But it is the way in which he produces this “no” that is of interest. Whitehead does not simply dismiss nature or science or sociology, however he does refuse

to accept that the social is something that immediately makes sense on its own terms. This is the first inkling that Whitehead takes the problem of the social seriously and sets out from the start to avoid some of its most insidious challenges to our thought.

Most importantly, Whitehead insists that we ask ourselves what it is that we think we are talking about when we use the word “social” or “society”. As has been seen, many working within sociology, social theory and the social sciences tend to use the word “social” a lot. This seems quite understandable. But, do we always know what we mean by the term? Often we use it in its adjectival form, when we talk of “social relations”, “social networks” or “social media”, for example. Yet, we also like to talk of *the* social; to treat it as a noun. Though we might be more wary than we used to be with regard to such a concept, it still lurks within our thoughts and our writings. There is also the question of what exactly constitutes the relation between the social and society. “Society” has become another worrisome term for sociology. As opposed to Durkheim, Marx and Weber, Whitehead is clear that the concept of the social is inextricably linked to that of society. However, in substantiating his point, he reformulates, radically, both of these concepts in a way which might initially surprise but could eventually prove beneficial. One of Whitehead’s most potent claims is that to assume that the social is solely or primarily a human affair is unwarranted and presumptuous. Whitehead neither accepts nor disregards nature or society, the natural or the social. Instead, he initially complicates but then clarifies the situation with regard to the thorny problem of their interrelation.

As a reminder of the kind of approach that Whitehead can help us argue against, I will briefly reconsider the work of Talcott Parsons and the extent to which it is emblematic of an uncritical acceptance of the status of the social (a fuller account can be found in Chapter Six). One important theme of Parsons’ work is that of “social order” (Parsons 1951, 1968a, 1968b). By “social order”, Parsons means those on-going elements which enable a society to endure. It does not necessarily mean that such a society is internally regimented, cohesive or smooth running. Rather, social order refers to the wider “social” structures, and the relations between these, which mean that the same society could be said to exist over time. Parsons’ concept of social order is one which tends to emphasize continuity and conformity at the expense of innovation or creativity. Interestingly, Parsons was a student at Harvard when Whitehead was teaching there in the 1920s and Whitehead certainly had some influence on the young Parsons, even if he sometimes misunderstood Whitehead (see Halewood 2008). One example of this was precisely that of the question of social order. Parsons tends to assume that the socialness of such social order is self-explanatory; it involves the institutions, values and behaviour of

humans in social groups. This is more of a description than an explanation as it invokes the very term social (as in “social groups”) to justify its account of social order. It is just this kind of approach which lays Parsons (and others) open to Whitehead’s charge, as cited at the start of this book, with regard to “how superficial are our controversies on sociological theory apart from some more fundamental determination of what we are talking about” (Whitehead 1933, 49).

Such a “fundamental determination” is precisely what Whitehead sets about in his elaboration of his concept of societies in *Process and Reality* (Whitehead 1978). His fullest discussion of these entities is to be found in Part II, Chapter III of the text which, notably, is titled “The Order of Nature”. This should alert us immediately that Whitehead has no truck with, or need for, a simple division between nature and society. Indeed, he leaves the very status of nature open at this stage, for his concern is, in these passages, the concept of order, not an investigation of the nature of nature. “The present chapter is wholly concerned with the topic of ‘order’” (Whitehead 1978, 83). Whitehead’s first point is that there is no such substantive thing as order (see Debaise 2006, 162–63) and, consequently, that order cannot be understood without reference to its corollary, namely disorder.³ Order is real and so is disorder but they can only occur in relation to each other. “Order is, above all, a relative term” (Debaise 2006, 164).⁴ But this is not to completely relativize these notions for there is a major difference between relativism and relationism, and Whitehead is speaking of the latter. In doing so, he uses a term which, as Stengers (e.g. 2008, 104, 114; 2011, 313, 513) points out, has great importance for him, namely that of “contrast”. Hence: “the correlative of ‘order’ is ‘disorder’”. There can be no peculiar meaning in the notion of ‘order’ unless this contrast holds” (Whitehead 1978, 83). Such a contrast does not refer to any simple binary division (either in thought or in reality). The importance of the notion of contrast is that it recognizes that the two terms only gain sense in relation to each other, rather than one being defined in opposition to the other. It might end up that it is not so much that there is nature *and* society, or the natural *and* the social: rather, they are contrasts.

This is, however, to jump ahead. Returning to the notion of order, Whitehead goes on to say: “‘Order’ is a mere generic term: there can only be some definite specific ‘order’ not merely ‘order’ in the vague” (Whitehead 1978, 83). Despite the high level of abstraction that Whitehead is working at, he is aware that, for his concept of order to have purchase, he must not attempt to capture some general realm of orderliness which is dislocated from, or prior to, actual manifestations of order. Order only makes sense in reference to specific occurrences of orderliness. The orderliness of order is not simply a repetition or reaction to that which comes before. If this were the case, if

order were simply the replication of the past, even if in a different form, then Whitehead would remain within the grips of a philosophy of necessity and fixed, immutable laws or logical possibilities. As Shaviro (2009, 71–72) has pointed out, one major aim and accomplishment of Whitehead's philosophy is precisely to place genuine novelty at the heart of his conceptual scheme and existence itself. Each occasion of orderliness is constituted by a novel incorporation of that which is given, along with a self-generating aim at being something different. That which is orderly about such occurrences is what Whitehead refers to as “adaptation for the attainment of an end” (Whitehead 1978, 83). This reasserts a vital element of his philosophy, namely “process” (as in the title of his major work, *Process and Reality*). To put it another way, the orderliness of an occasion equally involves establishing a past (constituting certain elements as given) and promulgating a future (that which is aimed at).

This introduction of “ends” which are to be attained might, to some, smack of teleology with all the associated problems of ideal goals that supposedly give reason and purpose to all existence; fixed or eternal ideals to which all things and people are inexorably drawn. This is not Whitehead's position.

There is not just one ideal “order” which all actual entities should attain and fail to attain. In each case there is an ideal peculiar to each particular actual entity [...] The notion of one ideal arises from the disastrous overmoralization of thought under the influence of fanaticism, or pedantry. (Whitehead 1978, 84)

Whitehead distances himself from those writers, such as Plato, who see the ideal as making up a unique and self-sufficient realm. In one sense, Whitehead is closer to Simmel's notion of “sociability” which he describes as the “pure process of sociation as a cherished value” (Simmel 1950, 44). On both accounts, the ideal does not pre-exist the comings-to-be which make up the world. The ideal and “ideal order” come about with the comings-to-be of different entities. Whitehead also avoids any traditional concept of teleology through the emphasis that he places on “failure”, which distances his position from that of Simmel. Whilst the aim at the attainment of an end is a real motivational element of each orderly occasion, the actual attainment or realization of such an end is always doomed to failure. This is for two reasons. First, as the ends to be attained do not exist in some separate realm prior to the specific bid for their attainment, then there is nothing (no thing) to attain, as such. Each end is generated anew on each occasion. Second, each occasion of order is a specific occasion which occurs in relation to a specific occurrence of givenness; givenness is not a substratum of existence. Instead, the givenness out of which the bid for novelty arises has the more limited role of partially comprising the environment within which such a bid plays out. Givenness

both enables and inhibits the end which is being aimed for. This inclusion of that which enables and inhibits is Whitehead's definition of "disorder":

every definite total phase of "givenness" involves a reference to that specific "order" which is its dominant ideal, and involves the specific "disorder" due to its inclusion of "given" components which exclude the attainment of the full ideal. The attainment is partial, and thus there is "disorder"; but there is some attainment, and thus there is some "order". (Whitehead 1978, 83–84)

This returns us to the correlation of order and disorder. At first sight, Whitehead's statement – though I paraphrase – that "there can be no order without disorder, and vice versa" might seem like a rather general, even banal, aphorism with little critical insight. But Whitehead's insistence upon the contrast between order and disorder as integral to all occasions of existence is, in fact, a bold philosophical statement (which will ultimately bring us back to questions of the status of societies and the social). Whitehead asks us to think order and disorder together without reducing one to the other. But it is quite a demand to envisage such a non-relativized doublet as inhering in all existence.

Nevertheless, it should be noted, at this point, that no real mention has yet been made of either nature or society, even though these terms were set up as important elements of this chapter. The reason for this is that while Whitehead does mention nature and society in Section I of Chapter III (Whitehead 1978, 83–89), he does so in passing and only turns to a full consideration of them in Section II.⁵ This careful procedure might be seen as a case of Whitehead taking his own advice regarding the need to undertake a "more fundamental determination of what we are talking about". There is no point in talking about the "order of nature" if we are unsure of what order is. So, with this notion of order now established, it is possible to move on to the status of nature and societies.

Order and Disorder in Nature and Society

The nature of nature is, of course, hard to ascertain. And Whitehead does not attempt to provide a once and for all definition. Instead, he is interested in an elaboration of the "order of nature" which he approaches thus: "We speak of the 'order of nature,' meaning thereby the order reigning in that limited portion of the universe, or even of the surface of the earth, which has come under our observation" (Whitehead 1978, 89). As will be clear, Whitehead is *not* attempting to provide a concept of nature at this point; this is no philosophy of nature (See Debaise 2006, 161–62). It is, rather, an outline of the problematic that he wants to address at this juncture, that is,

how order (and disorder) manifest themselves in existence. What is striking, for philosophers, scientists and social theorists, is that his first move is to introduce his own, specific concept of “society” or “societies”. As Debaise puts it: “What are the ‘orders’ at the heart of nature called? To what does this notion refer? Essentially, it refers to societies” (Debaise 2006, 162–63). Or, as Whitehead writes: “The term ‘society’ will always be restricted to mean a nexus of actual entities which are ‘ordered’ among themselves” (Whitehead 1978, 89). The use of inverted commas should warn us that Whitehead is aware that neither “societies” nor “order” have been fully explained. Nevertheless, it does point to Whitehead’s distinctive position, that the order of nature (whatever that is) can only be understood with reference to “societies”. There is to be no utter gulf between the natural and the social, nature and nurture, the individual and society. Societies are those elements of existence which exhibit and express the orderliness of existence and which, therefore, comprise those enduring things of the world which are encountered by the other enduring things of the world (be they humans, plants, galaxies, rocks, molecules or televisions).

The purely metaphysical account of existence that Whitehead develops in *Process and Reality* can, and must, be distinguished from his “cosmological” discussions of how the processes and principles are displayed in those enduring items of the world; items which encounter each other and which we, as humans, encounter, namely societies.⁶

For the moment, there are two points which need to be made clear. The first is that Whitehead has managed to introduce both nature (or, more precisely, the order of nature) *and* societies without mentioning humans. As I have discussed elsewhere (Halewood 2011, 86–89), the fact that Whitehead is able to develop an account of societies which is not predicated on the relation between humans, but which does not exclude specific human societies, as usually conceived, is a daring but productive challenge to sociological and social theory and avoids some of the problems raised in previous chapters regarding “the problem of the social”.

Second, Whitehead does not, at this stage, try to substantiate his concepts of nature and society. They are correlative, in a similar way to that in which order and disorder are correlative; he does not want to deny all elements of our usual understanding of these terms. He wants to forefront his stance that nature and society do not derive their specificity from some kind of internal essence, but from the *contrast* and *contrasts* upon which they rely and which they produce. It is these contrasts which enable societies to be what they are, to endure and to have effects. I will return to this point below.

At this stage, however, it might be objected that Whitehead has not really told us what is “social” about societies. What makes them exhibit the order of nature? His intriguing answer is that societies are social insofar as they express

an orderliness within nature (which is reminiscent of Durkheim's insistence that the social *is* natural, as outlined in Chapter Two). Unlike Parsons (1951) who starts by assuming that there is a self-sufficient realm of the social which is utterly human and is, in some ill-defined yet implacable and resolute way, divorced and different from the natural, Whitehead places the social at the heart of the natural. For, as far as nature is ordered it is social; it exhibits a "social order". This is an important point that Parsons missed, even though he was taught by Whitehead and, on occasions, claims to have been inspired by him (for example, Parsons 1968a, 29, 32).

A Society is a nexus which "illustrates" or "shares in", some type of "Social Order". "Social Order" can be defined as follows: – "A nexus enjoys 'social order' when (i) there is a common element of form illustrated in the definiteness of each of its included actual entities, and (ii) this common element of form arises in each member of the nexus by reason of the conditions imposed upon it by its prehensions of some other members of the nexus, and (iii) these prehensions impose that condition of reproduction by reason of their inclusion of positive feelings involving that common form["]". (Whitehead 1933, 260–61)

What is social about *social* order therefore involves the notions of "form" and "prehension".

The term "form" refers not to some realm of ideal Platonic forms (which actual entities or societies aim at) but the *manner* in which actual entities mutuallyprehend or grasp each other, thereby establishing a consistency which enables them to be, to endure, and to be recognized as a coherent "individual". As Debaise puts it: "That which Whitehead calls an element of form is none other than that which, at the level of actual entities, refers to the *manner* or the *how*, that is to say, the mode of prehension" (Debaise 2006, 139. Emphasis in original). An analogy could be made here to Simmel's development of "Formal Sociology", considered as a "Sociology of Forms" (see Chapter Seven). As has been discussed throughout this book (see also Halewood 2011, 27, 29, 98, 162; Shaviro 2009, 38, 56), the manner and mode of activity introduce the notion of the "adverbial". That is to say, rather than being substantive things in the usual sense (objects), societies derive their "thingness" through the way in which their constituents cohere. Societies should not be considered as primarily noun-like, that is as having some inner core of which qualities are predicated (see Debaise 2006, 141).⁷ Instead, societies come to be and endure through the shared manner in which their constituents regard each other (Stengers 2011, 321). Whitehead is, therefore, in agreement with, but goes beyond, Simmel's assertion that the notion of society as an object must be rejected in favour of an account which emphasizes the way in which individuals and societies come

to be. In both approaches, quality is dominant over quantity and the best way to understand and describe societies is to conceive of them as primarily adverbial. The social, as is the case with Durkheim, Marx and Weber, seems to be inextricably linked to “association”. Moreover, there is a striking similarity to Weber’s assertion that groupings gain their communal, and therefore, social character from the active mutual way in which the members of that group regard themselves as having something in common (see Chapter Five). However, Whitehead comes at this question of association from a different angle. The importance of the manner in which the components of a society regard each other and thereby hold themselves together refers to Whitehead’s specific rendering of the term “prehension”. Unlike Weber, this is not predicated on meaning or consciousness. This difference returns us to one of Whitehead’s primary assertions, namely that the social is not premised on human activity. Prehensions are not limited to human relations, though human relations are an example of complex prehensions. In the following discussion of prehensions, I will retain this specific word but it should be noted that in doing so, it could and should be read as an account of that which constitutes association.

To return to the long quotation given above, if the “identity” of a society is constituted by the common manner of prehension of its members, then that which does not prehend (associate) in that manner will be excluded from that society. The word “excluded” is, perhaps, too strong, as it invokes notions of an active form of negation carried out by a traditional kind of (human) agent. This is not Whitehead’s point. Rather, he emphasizes the notion of “likeness”. “The members of a society are alike [...] by reason of their common character” (Whitehead 1978, 89). The different characters of different societies are to be understood in terms of the likeness of character of the mutual regarding of the components of each society. The differences between societies are not to be thought of as divisive (though they are decisive) or exclusionary (though the members of one society will exclude those of others). The likeness of character once again brings the notion of quality to the fore, with regard to the existence of a society. Sociality is likeness. The social is premised on a notion of solidarity but one which is very different from that espoused by Durkheim, especially as it does not require a preconceived notion of totality or collectivity. Any totality or collectivity is an outcome not a precondition. The social, for Whitehead, is not something that subtends societies, it comes about on each occasion that a society comes to be and, more importantly, manages to endure.

All this returns us to the notion of “contrast”. For, it is the very contrast between the adverbial manner in which the members of one society commonly prehend (associate), and the different (contrasting) adverbial manner in which

the members of another society commonlyprehend (associate), that makes each society a definite individual. This contrast is not simply *between* societies, it inheres within the society, thereby making a society what it is. A hot stone and a cold stone are not different because there is some secret core of an implacable stone lying in wait to sometimes take on the quality of being hot, sometimes that of being cold, whilst somehow, mysteriously, remaining the same underneath. Instead, the mutual feeling of hotness by the component parts make up what we call “this hot stone”. Such a hot stone is a society, according to Whitehead. The individuality of this society arises from the contrast between its mutual feelings of hotness and the mutual feeling of coldness by the component parts of another society, which we might call “this cold stone”. To put it another way, one stone feels itself hotly and the other feels itself coldly. This shared feeling makes each stone what it is. A society. Similarly, the social is not a distinct realm within which societies occur or endure. Sociality comes to be in the self-generation of such societies. It is real but it does not have a separate reality from the specific existence of specific societies. In Marx’s sense of the term, societies and the social are inextricably tied up with the societal (see Chapter Four).

To sum up: Whitehead’s concept of societies is one that places the social, in terms of social order and societies, at the heart of existence, at the heart of nature. He also manages to elaborate his concept of the social without reference to, and without predicating it upon, the existence, intentions, beliefs, thoughts, actions or prejudices of humans. In doing so, he avoids the otherwise seemingly unavoidable split between the concerns and approaches of the harder sciences and those of social and cultural theory. There is no need to “bring things back in” to social theory, as they were always already there.

The Creation of Societies

To speak of “the creation of societies” quickly raises the question of who or what does the creating? Is it some external force which creates societies? Or, do they forge themselves out of nothing? In traditional sociological terminology, the question becomes, “What is the agent of transformation?” To frame the question in such ways is to limit the possible responses, according to Whitehead. Before proceeding to an outline of Whitehead’s own formulation, it is worthwhile pointing out that his concept of “creativity” is very particular. More than that, and surprising as it may seem, Whitehead coined the word “creativity” in the late 1920s as a technical, philosophical term to express a vital element of his philosophy (see Meyer 2007; Halewood 2011, 35–38 for a discussion of the extraordinary fact that the nowadays rather commonplace

term “creativity” was only invented around eighty-five years ago, within a very abstract metaphysical treatise).

It should be noted that there is a distinction to be drawn between creativity and creation. The first is a general metaphysical category, designed to express the fluency of existence, the latter is concerned with the specific occurrences of creativity which inhere in existence. Yet, Whitehead does not discuss the coming-to-be of societies in terms of creativity or creation, as such. To do so would be to invite us to rely upon the usual categories of thought where something is created by something or someone else. Whitehead is attempting to elicit a new mode of thought. To this end, he writes: “The point of a ‘society’ as the term is used here, is that it is self-sustaining, in other words, that it is its own reason” (Whitehead 1933, 261). This could be seen as similar to Durkheim’s claim that the social realm must be treated as *sui generis*. There are indeed some superficial similarities between Whitehead’s and Durkheim’s arguments here, in that to search for a reason external to a society is to posit an external creating force where there is none. However, Whitehead is aware that more philosophical work needs to be done to justify such a claim. Therefore, he goes on to argue that “Outside” of the society, prior to the society, there is only what might be called “undetermination” or disorder.⁸ “Beyond these societies there is disorder, where ‘disorder’ is a relative term expressing the lack of importance possessed by the defining characteristics of the societies in question beyond their own bounds” (Whitehead 1978, 92). It might be said that the “reason” for a society comes to be with the coming-to-be of that society; a society’s reason does not exist before the creation of that society, it is an outcome of that society’s self-creation; remembering that Whitehead’s societies are very different to those of Durkheim, and might involve things like rocks, transport systems or even the knowledge of the Greek language within an individual (Whitehead 1978, 89–90).

Whitehead does not deny regularity or law-like behaviour with regard to societies but he does refuse to posit them as examples of already-existing reasons or laws. “Thus in a society, the members can only exist by reason of the laws which dominate the society, and the laws only come into being by reason of the analogous characters of the members of the society” (Whitehead 1978, 91). This is another point where he differs from Durkheim. So-called laws are not fixed, they also come to be. Therefore, societies are not derived from more fundamental conditions; they establish the conditions for their own existence and, thereby, impose conditions upon the rest of existence. What is creative about a society is the specific, adverbial, manner in which it establishes these conditions, as opposed to the alternative ways in which it could have established itself (the stone feels itself hotly, not coldly). “Each task of creation is a social effort” (Whitehead 1978, 223).

There is, therefore, a creativity inherent in the self-identity of each society which is precisely that which differentiates it from other societies; this provides the society with its definiteness, with its individuality. It is in this respect that a society could be referred to as “self-creating”, rather than self-causing (*causa sui*). “The self-identity of a society is founded upon the self-identity of its defining characteristics, and upon the mutual immanence of its occasions” (Whitehead 1933, 262). Whitehead’s use of the phrase “mutual immanence” is crucial. It reminds us of one of the most important aspects of his very definition of a society: that the manner of the mutual regarding of each member of that society makes that society what it is. In this respect he develops some of the ideas nascent in both Weber and Simmel. “The members of the society are alike because, by reason of their common character, they impose on other members of the society the conditions which lead to that likeness” (Whitehead 1933, 261). However, Whitehead does not reduce this likeness to the shared rational intentions of the human members of that group, as Weber does. In this respect, and as Debaise (2006) makes clear, in order to approach a full understanding of Whitehead’s point, it is necessary to conceive of his notion of existence as a mode of “possession”; existence is a matter of “having” rather than simply “being” (Debaise 2006, 70–71): “The notion of ‘societies’ develops further the primacy of having [*l’avoir*] over being [*l’être*] by placing identity within having [*l’avoir*]” (Debaise 2006, 145). This is why societies are their own reason. It is the similar mode of membership of that society which enables its members to cohere and inhere, to create the specificity which is that society. These members can be individual humans, but they do not have to be. They could be made up entirely of non-human entities or a mixture of human and non-human entities, as long as they had a common mode of prehension or association. It is the novel manner of this coherence which establishes the specific identity of any such society. There is no identity prior to that coherence. This enables a full definition of a society, finally, to be given, which Debaise does in the following way: “We now obtain the conditions for a definition of societies, in the form of a precise question which must be asked of each of them: what does a society *possess* in terms of its components and how do these *hold* themselves together?” (Debaise 2006, 145. Emphasis in original).

Whitehead’s account of the creation of societies challenges us to rethink the relations between an individual and society, its members and the environment: “a society is, for each of its members, an environment with some element of order in it, persisting by reason of the genetic relations between its own members. Such an element of order is the order prevalent in the society” (Whitehead 1978, 90). This reference to “order” neatly links to a previous element of this chapter, where order was established as that relational term

whereby nature organizes itself into particular moments of specificity; it is thus creative in so far as there is the creation of societies. There is, therefore, no problematic distinction between the natural and the social, the real and the artificial, the genetic and the cultural. Objects and subjects are outcomes of a manner of combination. It is this “manner of combination” which constitutes a culture (rather than some enduring “way of life”). In so far as all those things which we normally consider to be objects are really societies, Stengers points out that “Everything is sociology” (Stengers 2011, 325). Whitehead would agree, and would do so in a dual manner. First, at the metaphysical level, all enduring existence is a matter of societies. This condition also applies at the “human” level, in that that which is normally considered to constitute a human society does not escape the demands of Whitehead’s metaphysics. Second, and as was discussed in the initial stages of this chapter, sociology, considered as the study of human societies, has its place, though it is a very specific one.

Conclusion

It is now possible to incorporate the discussion of the status of societies, considered as elements of the general ordering of existence, with Whitehead’s novel vision of “sociology”, as introduced at the beginning of this chapter. Each society requires a common mode of association (prehension), the shared manner in which each individual within that society regards all other members, which thereby constitutes the society as a specific society. The same applies at the human level. “In any one human society, one fundamental idea tingeing every detail of activity is the general conception of the status of the individual members of that group, considered apart from any pre-eminence” (Whitehead 1933, 11). So, it is an idea which is grasped by each member of a society, even if it is only grasped obliquely, unconsciously, which enables each individual to consist as both an individual and as a member of that society. Capitalism, perhaps, is such an idea, a real abstraction which has had such deleterious consequences.⁹

Further, the mode of analysis required for an understanding of the constitution of each society, and a comparison of societies, is that of contrast. The specificity and definiteness of a society comes from the contrasts within it and between it and other societies. Whitehead calls upon various contrasts throughout *Adventures of Ideas*. There is the contrast between “force and persuasion” (Whitehead 1933, 87ff.) and that between “freedom and compulsion” (Whitehead 1933, 83–86). It is not so much that either of these exist separately or in their own terms. Rather, it is the contrast between the two different dynamic aspects of these contrasts that expresses what is of importance.

It is a matter of productive tension and it is in this respect that Whitehead can, finally, offer a definition of sociology and sociological theory.

The foundation of all understanding of sociological theory – that is to say, of all understanding of human life – is that no static maintenance of perfection is possible. This axiom is rooted in the nature of things. Advance or Decadence are the only choices offered to mankind [*sic*]. The pure conservative is fighting against the essence of the universe [...]

[For] the very essence of real actuality – that is, of the completely real, is *process*. (Whitehead 1933, 353–54)

This ties together many of the themes that have been raised in this book. Sociological theory, as an account of “human life”, might well look at human societies, but will have to reformulate what it considers these to be. The key to understanding this is to realize that all existence is a matter of process. This notion of process is a crucial element of much classical social theory, especially in the texts of Marx and Simmel. However, it must be asserted, against certain postmodernists, that such process is not mere flux or becoming. We are not at the end of the social but we need to rethink our concept of the social. The social was a major concern for sociology in its early years but its importance was overlooked or forgotten throughout much of the twentieth century. One aim of this book has been to reinvigorate the problem of the social and to indicate some ways in which we might re-engage with this important concept, retaining some of the insights of Durkheim, Marx and Weber, but also developing a novel philosophical position.

According to Whitehead, the solidity (or even the solidarity), which appears within existence through its enduring elements, is always social (in the widest sense of the term), in that it is only societies which manage to cohere and endure. All existence is social in that all enduring entities comprise societies. The social is, in one sense, natural, but without invoking any form of essentialism; thus going beyond the limitations of the Durkheimian approach. There is a form of solidarity to existence but this is not only evident in human societies. As Marx insisted throughout his works, we have to develop a genuine understanding of process and of the items which appear within such process. But, just as creativity is of itself neutral, process, of itself, is neither good nor bad.

Furthermore, within human societies, ideas, as things, play a crucial role but not the only role. “Men [*sic*] are driven by their thoughts as well as by the molecules in their bodies, by intelligence and by senseless forces” (Whitehead 1933, 58). As will by now be clear, such thoughts are not to be viewed as the creations of humans (to be studied only by sociocultural analyses, as Weber

might hold), they are, rather, that which enables us to develop our humanity, rather than us being merely human. The ways in which this has happened are what constitutes history. Human thoughts are aspects of the differing careers of ideas as they adventure throughout existence. Equally, senseless forces are not merely the deterministic, ironclad, laws of nature which dictate an uncomprehending but unstoppable rolling-out of existence along a preordained path, be it in terms of scientific laws or societal progress. Senseless forces exhibit the unrelenting process of existence, no matter what we think of it, or how we try to ignore it: “life is an offensive, directed against the repetitious mechanism of the Universe. It is the thesis of this discussion that a policy of sociological defence is doomed to failure” (Whitehead 1933, 102).

Having said all this, Whitehead was a philosopher and not a sociologist, but his distinction between the twin couplets of society–social and sociology–sociological is an important one which enables accounts of the humanly social to take their place within or beside other accounts of existence. It certainly does not relegate social or sociocultural analyses to the sidelines, leaving the so-called hard sciences to take on the real reality. It is one important way in which he avoids “the problem of the social”. For much contemporary social theory, the social is still a problem. Not because it is some kind of thing; it does not constitute a separate realm which we have to investigate and reconcile with other realms, such as the natural (whatever that might be). Rather, the problem of the social lies in the difficulties that it creates for us in thinking of, and acting in, the world. It is a problem which was present in the work of Durkheim, Marx and Weber but which has been glossed over in more recent social theory. However, within our conceptual landscape, the problem of the social needs to be resurrected and dealt with fully. I believe that the work of Whitehead offers us one bold way to accomplish this. The demands that he makes of us might seem strange, they may seem risky in that they ask us to radically reconsider many of the most basic stanchions of sociology and social theory. However, to acquiesce in the face of these problems seems even more dangerous as it might lead to sociology becoming ineffective and irrelevant. We need a bold philosophy of the social which will take up this call to investigate some of our most cherished beliefs. Such a philosophy would not mean rejecting out of hand the works of writers such as Durkheim, Marx and Weber. Indeed, one main argument of this book is that we have been overhasty in assuming that we know what they had to say on these matters. As earlier chapters attempted to demonstrate, although there is some incoherence and inconsistency in their texts, there are also novel insights which seem to have been forgotten and which could still be utilized in developing a more robust approach.

To my mind, Whitehead offers us the framework for developing such a robust approach. He reminds us that we cannot take anything for granted,

be it a general theory of human societies or the existence of the social as a discrete realm. Other terms, such as “social relations”, “social facts” and “social reasons” must also be treated with suspicion, and jettisoned if necessary. We need to investigate how it is that the societies which we encounter (and these might be anything from a website to a riot) manage to come to be, to hold together, sustain themselves, or not. This will involve a reorientation of our concepts and means that we may be less sure with regard to a range of traditional (social) explanations which many social theorists hold dear. Finally, if social theory is itself taken to be a society, in Whitehead’s sense, then, if it is not to perish entirely, it must grasp the nettle of novelty, leave behind many of its comforting but outdated concepts and procedures, and seize some kind of a future, whatever the cost. For:

It is the first step in sociological wisdom, to recognize that the major advances in civilization are processes which all but wreck the societies in which they occur: – like unto an arrow in the hand of a child. The art of free society consists [...] in fearlessness of revision. (Whitehead 1927, 88)